

+ Prime focus

Young grower innovates with a QRIDA Sustainability Loan

Maintaining a family business in primary production for over 100 years is no mean feat. Thriving through unpredictable weather and changing economies (all while inspiring the kids to follow suit) requires grit, adaptability and a great mind for business – like that seen in the Kingston family of Wilarene Farm.

When the Kingstons arrived from England in the late 1800s, they were among the first to settle in the Cordalba area near Bundaberg where they started growing sugarcane. Today, John and Sharyn Kingston - along with one of their three children - are continuing the family tradition, but with their own twist through diversification and growth. Today their farm is producing avocados and hydroponically grown baby cucumbers, as well as continuing their commitment to sugar.

“The [QRIDA] loan gives us lower interest rates, more attractive terms and conditions, and the ability - if disaster strikes - to extend interest only payments.”

“We believe that in a rapidly changing world, having the ability to change will be the key to another successful generation of Kingstons farming in the area,” said John.

“We believe hydroponics offer the quality, blemish-free products that the markets and population are demanding - these are some of the things conventional farming struggle to deliver.”



QRIDA client, Matt Kingston in his family's greenhouse

This venture is championed by their son Matt and housed in a 4,000 metre-square green house funded by a QRIDA Sustainability Loan. Matt played a hands-on role in building the structure, which features cutting edge climate control and monitoring systems. It currently houses the baby cucumbers, known as “qukes.”

These crisp, finger length cucumbers are rapidly increasing in demand as a healthy and convenient snack food. With Bundaberg known as one of Queensland's most quickly advancing horticultural regions, Matt's extensive research, planning and knowledge gained from local industry experts gave them confidence in what to expect from hydroponic production - allowing them to make an informed decision before taking the plunge.

He was also able to obtain a fixed price contract for the product, giving the Kingstons the confidence they needed to proceed with their diversification.

“Business planning, risk assessments and succession planning were some of the tools and processes that were undertaken along the way,” Sharyn said.

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From the CEO's desk

As 2017 draws to a close it's a good time to reflect on the year that was and look forward to what 2018 will bring, both for our organisation and for Queensland's rural and regional industries.

This year has been a busy one for us - punctuated by our name change on 1 July, which has allowed us to do more for Queensland industry and rural communities.

But this has not been the only highlight of the year - others that come to mind include our approval of more than \$268 million in loans, grants, rebates and subsidies in 2016-2017 (more than twice the previous financial year), our immediate response to those affected by Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie and provision of more than \$18.7 million in disaster assistance for this event to date, establishment of our ninth regional office in Cloncurry and let's not forget the introduction of Farm Management Grants and the Farm Business Debt Mediation program.

Undoubtedly, our First Start and Sustainability Loans have also continued to be instrumental in advancing Queensland's rural industries, with a record amount of more than \$116 million provided under these loans in 2016-2017.

During our recent trip to the Scenic Rim and Darling Downs, the QRIDA Board and I were lucky enough to visit clients who've expanded their farming enterprises with the help of these loans.

I really get a great thrill out of seeing how the assistance we've provided clients, like Ed and Gen Windley (pictured), has been expertly put to use to achieve their dream of operating a profitable primary production enterprise.

I encourage producers who'd like to realise their own farming dreams to contact their local QRIDA Regional Area Manager to talk about which loan is best for them.

Looking forward now to 2018, QRIDA is gearing up for the launch of the Farm Debt Restructure Office, the close of



The QRIDA Board & CEO, Cameron MacMillan visiting clients Ed & Gen Windley in the Scenic Rim

applications for Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie grant assistance on 12 January and our continuing role in advancing Queensland's rural and regional industries with the administration of our range of loan and grant assistance programs.

From all of us at QRIDA, we wish you a happy and safe Christmas and look forward to working with you again in the new year.

- Cameron MacMillan

Innovate with a Sustainability Loan

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"The [QRIDA] loan gives us lower interest rates, more attractive terms and conditions, and the ability - if disaster strikes - to extend interest only payments."

Sustainability Loans assist Queensland producers in improving, expanding and diversifying their operations for long term success - they can be used for projects ranging from green houses like the Kingstons', to alternative energy systems, soil improvement measures and on-farm processing equipment.

The family's way of life isn't one they'd ever want to trade, but they also know that evolving their business is essential to maintaining it.

"John was born in this area and has worked in this environment all his life - [he] has never thought of living anywhere else," said Sharyn.



An aerial view of the Kingston's green house

"When [we] married, this tradition was carried on - we believe raising children in this lifestyle brings different values and opportunities to them.

"The long term goal is to have varied risk pools, so we can ride out the ups and downs of primary production."

Following recent changes, Sustainability Loans of up to \$1.3 million are available on repayment terms of up to 20 years, with interest rates as low as 3.20% and no fees or charges. For more information visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au.

Resources available for Farm Business Debt Mediation

Farm Business Debt Mediation has now been compulsory for several months, preventing mortgagees foreclosing on farm business debt without undergoing a formal, impartial mediation process.

Although no one plans for it, sometimes poor seasonal conditions continue, personal circumstances change and business options may become limited. When this happens, the mediation process is in place to protect you and your family business.

Our website has a range of resources to help you understand the program and to prepare for it should you need to undergo mediation.

Visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au/fbdm for more or email contact_fbdm@qrida.qld.gov.au with any queries.

+ QRIDA assistance

Need help tackling drought?

As some parts of Queensland face extended dry conditions and others have received enough rainfall to start making plans for recovery, it can be hard to know what to do next.

Craig Turner, Manager of Client Relations, says that although instinct might be to bunker down and wait for conditions to improve, producers should be looking into ways to take charge of their current situation.

"We might not be able to control the seasons, but what we can control is our own financial position," he said.

"Don't wait for things to pick up - whether you need to give yourself some breathing space by refinancing commercial debt or access funds to cover immediate costs, there are options you can act on now to put yourself in a better position."

QRIDA delivers Drought Assistance Concessional Loans, a Commonwealth Government initiative intended to give primary producers support in the face of drought, no matter which stage of the battle you may be in.

The versatile loans provide up to \$1 million, currently at an interest rate of just 3.09 per cent, which can be used to restructure existing debt – including



previous Commonwealth loans – to reduce interest and repayment pressure, or to access funds to cover pressing day-to-day operating costs.

Beyond relieving financial stress while still in the grips of drought, the program can also provide new funds to help producers recover when it lifts, allowing you to replant or restock.

You also don't need to be in a drought-declared area or a one-in-twenty zone to have suffered significantly, so if you can demonstrate two years of impact, look into your options.

Find more at www.qrida.qld.gov.au or Freecall 1800 623 946 to talk to our team about what may be possible.

Drought Assistance Concessional Loans are delivered in Queensland by QRIDA on behalf of the Commonwealth Government.

2018 Rainfall Chart available

Keep track of the rainfall on your property with our easy to use online Rainfall Chart for 2018.

Download yours today from our website at www.qrida.qld.gov.au/rainfall-chart.

Natural Disaster Assistance update

Central Coast Queensland Severe Weather, 16-18 October

Category B Natural Disaster Loans of up to \$250,000 have been activated for primary producers impacted by the severe rainfall and flooding in Bundaberg, Gladstone and North Burnett Regional Councils. Essential Working Capital Loans of up to \$100,000 are also available for producers whose enterprises were not physically damaged, but did suffer financial loss due to the event.

At the time of publication, Category C Natural Disaster Recovery Grants of up to

\$25,000 have been made available to impacted producers in specific districts in the North Burnett Regional Council area - see our website for latest details and a map of eligible zones.

Severe Tropical Cyclone Debbie and Associated Rainfall and Flooding

Primary producers, small businesses and non-profit organisations affected by Cyclone Debbie and the resulting floods still have until 12 January 2018 to apply for up to \$25,000 in recovery grants for clean-up, restoration and repairs. Visit www.qrida.qld.gov.au for more.

Tell us what you think

Prime Focus was launched in 2004 to keep our clients and partners informed about our programs and issues relevant to rural and regional industries.

To ensure we continue to keep our newsletter relevant to your needs, we'd love to hear from you about how you read the publication and what you'd like to see more of in future issues.

To participate in our quick online survey reviewing *Prime Focus*, please visit <http://bit.ly/PFwebsurvey>

+ Regional update



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Succession a conversation starter

I've been heartened by the positive response received from professionals throughout my area to the availability of Farm Management Grants, which have proven very effective in assisting all family members start the succession conversation. First Start Loans have also been a significant catalyst for farm succession to commence across my region, with successful applications from horticulture, grazing and cane growing enterprises.

I'm available to outline the benefits of the grants and our First Start Loans to both you and your advisers – get in touch to make an appointment.



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TC Debbie assistance extended

Grant assistance for those impacted by TC Debbie has been extended until 12 January 2018. This extension provides canegrowers, especially, time to complete the repairs to their cultivation and infrastructure.

NDRRA loans are available to assist affected enterprises not only with repairs, but also support of working capital and cashflow shortfalls.

QRIDA understands that recovery from events like cyclones take time. I encourage you to make contact so we can work through your individual circumstances to find the best solution for your business.



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First Start to success

It was a privilege to showcase achievements of several First Start Loan recipients to QRIDA's Board on a recent tour. The clients represented the horticulture and dairy industries, and all displayed a fantastic commitment to understanding and developing their markets, utilising best practice and remaining clear on their long-term goals. Their focus was as much on being better business managers as on being better farmers. These clients had committed their minds and financial resources to being productive primary producers - if this is you, call me so we can discuss how QRIDA can be a partner in developing your business.



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Sustainability allows diversification

Investment in quality farming land has continued with significant increases in land values realised. Many farmers are diversifying further with additional investment in tree crops and sweet potatoes.

QRIDA is proud to support producers diversifying their business - using Sustainability Loans we've assisted those currently producing lower value commodities to expand into higher value crops. Common to all successful applications is a considered management plan and realistic budgets. I can provide you with support to ensure your applications demonstrate your goals and aligns with the intent of our lending.



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Benefits delivered through partnerships

QRIDA continues to enjoy some wonderful partnerships in my region. Local bank managers acknowledge the assistance QRIDA loans provide to our mutual clients and happily participate in joint lending agreements to benefit those clients. In turn, clients appreciate the personal assistance and on-farm support QRIDA provides to them and their banks.

The support local producers continue to receive from the Rural Financial Counselling Service should also be acknowledged. As a free service they're a wonderful resource to producers and play a crucial role in developing cashflows to support loan applications.



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Succession requires a sound base

I've recently been involved with several workshops advising primary producers and their families about rural succession. A clear message regarding succession is the need for the current business to be on a firm, profitable footing to pave the way for future generations to be successful.

Sustainability Loans can assist with expanding or developing your current enterprise to be more productive, resilient and allow for effective succession in the future. I can meet with you on farm to assist with your business plans and applications - call me to make an appointment.



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Prepare for better times

With many districts having moved back into a 1-in-10-year rainfall deficiency, I encourage anyone yet to access Drought Assistance Concessional Loans to contact me and make use of the assistance to free up your cashflow through refinancing existing debt.

It is better to access these loans based on what you can control rather than holding back waiting for a break to utilise the funds to restock.

A number of graziers have also been able to access Sustainability Loans for infrastructure upgrades at the same time as utilising drought loans.



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Support comes in many different forms

Recent storms and flooding has meant headaches for producers in the southern areas of my region. NDRRA loans have been activated for the council areas of Gladstone, North Burnett and Bundaberg. These loans are designed to assist with repairs, replanting, restocking and covering working capital shortfalls created by the event.

Some districts struggled with drought prior to the flooding; producers are encouraged to contact me to discuss the programs available to assist them. It may be that a combination of loans will provide the best financial solution to ensure recovery from extreme weather events.



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Drought loans provide options

It's been great to visit all corners of my region in recent months to discuss the benefits of QRIDA programs - particularly the diverse applications Drought Assistance Concessional Loans can have for graziers. Some enterprises are in recovery mode whilst others are dealing with dry conditions. These loans not only provide funds to improve cashflow through refinancing existing debt, but can also provide funds for restocking and implementing preparedness activities. To access the loans your enterprise needs to have been impacted by drought, but does not necessarily need to be in drought now. Call me for more information.

Disclaimer: the information provided by QRIDA is general information only and has been prepared without taking into account your individual objectives, financial situation and needs. Before applying for financial assistance or making any decision, you should obtain and read a copy of the relevant program guidelines and seek advice from your legal, business and financial advisers to determine your eligibility for, and the terms of the relevant financial assistance. You should note that past grants of financial assistance are not a reliable indicator of eligibility for future grants of financial assistance. The information provided by QRIDA has been taken from sources believed to be reliable however QRIDA does not represent that the information is accurate or complete and it should not be relied upon as such. QRIDA does not assume any common law duty of care towards you in providing the information and QRIDA will not be liable for any loss or damage however caused (including by the negligence of QRIDA), suffered or incurred by you in connection with information provided by QRIDA.